Prologue: A Voyage among the Holes

in which the reader,
in a science fiction tale,
encounters black holes
and all their strange properties
as best we understand them in the 1990s

Of all the conceptions of the human mind, from unicorns to gargoyles to. the hydrogen bomb, the most fantastic, perhaps, is the black hole: a hole in space with a definite edge into which anything can fall and out of which nothing can escape; a hole with a gravitational force so strong that even light is caught and held in its grip; a hole that curves space and warps time.[1] Like unicorns and gargoyles, black holes seem more at home in the realms of science fiction and ancient myth than in the real Universe. Nonetheless, well-tested laws of physics predict firmly that black holes exist. In our galaxy alone there may be millions, but their darkness hides them from view. Astronomers have great difficulty finding them.[2]

Hades

Imagine yourself the owner and captain of a great spacecraft, with computers, robots, and a crew of hundreds to do your bidding. You have been commissioned by the World Geographic Society to explore black holes in the distant reaches of interstellar space and radio back to Earth a description of your experiences. Six years into its voyage, your starship is